

Viraj Bansal
CEO, Vans Electro Engineering

Ideas & Innovations

Viraj Bansal, CEO, Vans Electro Engineering, believes innovation and inclusivity are the keys to achieving long-term goals

Author, entrepreneur, engineer--you don many hats. Please share your journey with us.

My journey as an entrepreneur started during my undergraduation days. The internships exposed me to new cultures and experiences, igniting a desire to travel outside my comfort zone, explore new technologies and understand what the future could hold. One of the most memorable and enriching month-long internships was in Brazil, where I was the only student from my university.

Along with studies, I also founded start-ups—one focused on drone delivery of medical items to improve access to medical supplies in remote areas. We were selected amongst the Top100 technology-driven start-ups by Start-up Istanbul. The other start-up focused on solving late-night eating habits of students by installing vending machines so that they were provided hot food.

I completed my master's in Engineering Management from University of Warwick, United Kingdom. With all my learnings, my aim was to bring better technology to India and these experiences helped in that.

My journey began when I returned to India and looked into the country's financial budget. I was surprised to find that a significant portion was allocated to Indian railways. Upon further research, I discovered the 2x25 electrification policy aimed at improving transportation efficiency for trains at higher speeds. With my background in Electrical Engineering, I saw an opportunity and discussed the idea with my mentors. Together, we founded Vans Electro Engineering, focusing on B2G, or business to government.

Under the Vans Electro Engineering banner, we developed high voltage switchgears, Vacuum Circuit breakers (VCB), and Vacuum Interrupters (VI) for Indian railways. Our company was amongst the first to manufacture switchgear products under the 2x25 electrification policy, and we conducted tests at renowned testing labs worldwide.

I am immensely grateful to my mentors Abhishek Saraff, Balakrishnan Srinivasan, and Nitin Jain, whose unwavering belief in me and my abilities played a vital role in the development of this unique product. Without their guidance, support, and expertise, I would not have been able to realize this idea.

Please share your learnings from this journey, as you are now heading a company with diverse products.

Along this journey, I have learned valuable lessons about innovation, entrepreneurship and the importance of investing in technology. There were challenges, as we had to work on mindsets and adapting to change, along with mentorship.

Despite all this, the future looks bright. I find that there is ease of doing business under the 'Make in India' scheme. Banks are more conducive to giving loans to SMEs and MSMEs. The manufacturing and start-up culture in India is booming. All we need to do is push our ideas and keep innovating.

I started Vans Electro Engineering in February 2022. It took me a whole year to develop the product for Indian railways, and we have all the approvals by the government now. This showcases the ease of doing business in India for startups like us.

You have also authored a book, Handbook of Engineering Management. How did this happen?

By chance, I discovered the subject of Engineering Management while selecting courses for my master's degree. As a technical person with an interest in management, this was the perfect fit for me. During the pandemic, I found myself stranded in London and utilized my time to create notes on the subject. A friend suggested that I publish them, and with his help, I edited and published the book.

What are the future plans?

India boasts a population of around 1.39 billion. The percentage of youth in India is impressive, with over 50% of the population under the age of 25. This demographic presents an enormous opportunity for investment in India's youth.

Investing in India's youth can unlock enormous potential and lead to innovative solutions to global challenges. With its booming economy, diverse sectors, and supportive policies, India is indeed a gold mine of opportunities, and anything and everything is possible here.

We plan to diversify our products to other sectors also. We will keep innovating and making more environmentally sustainable and cost-effective products that will help India to prosper.

